

₹15,290 crore).

Despite these soaring valuations, Modi believes the league's true commercial potential is still far from fully realised. He reiterated that the IPL was originally conceived as an independent entity rather than a subsidiary of the BCCI, with a governance structure that would have placed franchise owners at the centre of decision-making, similar to the model followed in major American sports leagues.

"That was how it was proposed on September 13, 2007, and the BCCI Governing Council approved that the IPL was not a subsidiary of the BCCI. It was an independent company," Modi told *Sportstar*.

"I got a lot of backlash... 'if you want to launch it, it's going to be this way.' It was set up with the owner sitting on the board and controlling it like the National Football League (NFL). I will reveal that Constitution one day, but that is actually the fact of what was approved in the Special General Meeting prior to the press conference that I held. Thereafter, it was changed in November or December 2007, in Jaipur, where others got involved and said that this can't be done."

Modi recalled that resistance to an independent league structure meant compromises had to be made to ensure the tournament's launch remained on track. While he acknowledges that the IPL has achieved unprecedented success over the past 18 years, he believes the league might have grown even more rapidly had the original governance framework been retained. With the majority not in favour of creating an independent league, Modi admitted he had "many fires to douse" and chose his battles.

"Had the original structure remained, with owners represented on the board and the league controlling its own operations, the IPL would by now have been an ecosystem unto itself. It would have been untouchable by any company of any kind on the planet," he said. "We would be controlling everything and marketing our own product through our own streaming system

globally by now."

That tension between vision and control would, in time, lead to a far more consequential rupture.

Back in 2013, Modi was found guilty on eight counts of "various acts of indiscipline and misconduct" by the BCCI's disciplinary committee, a decision that culminated in his expulsion from Indian cricket's administrative structure.

Since leaving India in 2010, Modi has faced over two dozen cases, including multiple investigations by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) for alleged financial irregularities, money laundering, and violations under FEMA. Investigations have also involved the Income Tax Department, the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence, and passport authorities, with non-bailable warrants issued in certain cases. Modi is yet to physically appear before an Indian court in these matters.

More than a decade on, Modi continues to contest both the process and the substance of those findings. He maintains that the allegations against him were never tested in a court of law and that no formal charges were framed in a judicial setting.

He also questions the procedural fairness of the BCCI's internal disciplinary proceedings, claiming he was denied a meaningful opportunity to present his case before the committee.

"I wasn't even given a fair hearing. The day I was to appear before the committee and answer questions, I was effectively banned before I could present my case," Modi said.

The Kochi IPL franchise controversy in 2010 was the one that truly opened the floodgates of the accusations against him. Modi was accused of rigging the bidding in favour of a few corporate players and arm-twisting stakeholders thereafter. He suggested that he had faced sustained pressure to step down but chose not to do so voluntarily. He alleged that attempts were made to prevent him from addressing the public at the time, although the speech was eventually

broadcast.

"I was asked to resign and told I could return in six months. I said, 'If you have the guts, fire me.'..." he said.

In his telling, the rupture was not of his making. It is a story of power and politics, of people of influence who, he believes, chose to turn on him. To him, it is less about wrongdoing and more about being pushed out of a system he helped build.

Positioning his defence within his business background, Modi emphasised that he had no financial incentive to engage in wrongdoing.

It is an argument of inheritance. Modi was born into wealth — heir to the KK Modi enterprise, with interests spanning tobacco, hospitality, and chemicals — a life that began with a 'diamond spoon'.

"I come from an established business family; I did not need to take money from the league. The KK Modi Group is valued in the hundreds of thousands of crores. The suggestion that I would risk everything for relatively small sums makes no sense," Modi claimed.

He added that he had retained documentation relating to key decisions taken during his tenure and reiterated his belief that a full legal process would bring greater clarity.

"I have always said that if the matter is tested in court, the full record will emerge through discovery. Despite the controversies, the IPL has only grown stronger. If I had to do it again, I would still take the same decisions because they ultimately strengthened the league."

When he speaks, there is an unyielding certainty — something close to the belief that he could not have been wrong, a trait not unfamiliar among those cast out yet unconvinced.

That certainty extends beyond his defence of the past to his reading of the present and, in particular, what he believes the IPL is still getting wrong.

Home and away is where the value is

While Modi believes the IPL's